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MANN IN THE MIDDLE

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BHAGWANT MANN
Chief Minister, Punjab

The comedian-turned-politician's euphoric win in Punjab polls was a turning point for not just the state but the Aam Aadmi Party too

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

These days, along the national highways in Punjab, the alternating scenes of lush wheat fields in the countryside and the hubbub of towns and cities are frequently punctuated by life-size billboards of a tight-faced Bhagwant Mann, the chief minister. They proudly declare the Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP) success in delivering on its poll promise of providing free electricity. In a head-turning sweep, Mann stormed into power in Punjab with 92 AAP legislators in March 2022. Perhaps the comedian-turned-politician's victory was not entirely without notice—rivals Congress and the Akali Dal were already engulfed in their own big crises. Even so, it was a turning point for the AAP, and a sliver of hope for a state whose struggles had been ballooning for years.

Mann is the AAP's second chief minister after party convenor and Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal. The party has sought to position him like Beppe Grillo of Italy, or Volodymyr Zelenskyy of Ukraine, both satirists-turned-politicians. But while Grillo is at pains to take control of his own party, Zelenskyy is facing one of the worst crises Europe has seen as he battles Vladimir Putin's aggression. In this perhaps the comparisons aren't entirely incorrect, with Mann, too, struggling to find a firm footing in Punjab.

Nine months into his chief ministership, Mann is grappling with poor state finances, lack of control over his own administration, flak for alleged alcoholism, and dwindling private investment. The AAP's commitment to freebies isn't helping him either. Punjab has turned from 'debt-stressed' to a 'debt-trapped' state, and as per estimates, its debt burden may touch Rs 3.05 lakh crore by the end of the current fiscal. In June 2022, the AAP faced its first jolt as it lost to Simranjit Singh Mann of the Akali Dal in the Sangrur bypoll. To many, this seemed like the first marker of the party's performance so far. Ironically, with the AAP trying to expand its nationwide footprint—especially after its impressive performance in Gujarat in December—Punjab was to be the party's laboratory, a national showcase for its model of governance.

Mann's biggest challenges are the dismal state finances and the fast-eroding control over his own administration

When Mann started campaigning, Punjab had already been battling a menacing drug problem, difficult bureaucracy, and a hangover of decades of radical terror. He fought hard, promising change to voters who had grown disillusioned with traditional parties in the state. Now that he is in the hot seat, he may do well to learn—and soon—that leading a complex border state is no cakewalk, and regaining control of his government is his only way forward. ■